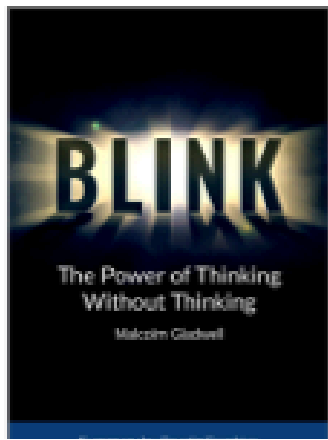




BLINK

The Power of Thinking Without Thinking

Malcolm Gladwell



The Big “So What”

Have you ever wondered how you make snap decisions? In this book, Malcolm Gladwell uses scientific research, anecdotes, and expert insights to unveil the power and pitfalls of intuitive judgment. He explains how we use “thin-slicing” to gauge a situation rapidly, and offers tips to improve the quality and accuracy of our decisions.



Introduction



The book opens with a story that shows how instinctive, snap judgments can be as good as logical, deliberate analysis.

- The Getty Museum in Los Angeles was about to purchase a kouros, an ancient Greek statue. There were only about 200 kouros known to exist, making this a rare and valuable artifact. The museum experts did a comprehensive authenticity check over 14 months, using various scientific tests to analyze the material and age of the statue—and concluded that it was authentic.
- Yet, when art historians and experts saw the kouros, many instantly sensed that something wasn't right. True enough, further investigations revealed inconsistencies that suggested the kouros might indeed be a counterfeit. How did the experts detect the problem in just seconds or minutes, when the museum team had failed to do so after months of detailed analysis?



In this book, Gladwell emphasizes the importance of trusting our instincts, with 3 key messages:

- Snap judgments can be as effective as those made from lengthy deliberations.

KEY QUOTES

“Decisions made very quickly can be every bit as good as decisions made cautiously and deliberately.”

- Our instincts can sometimes mislead us. Gladwell speculates that the Getty Museum team might have been so eager to acquire the kouros that they overlooked their own instincts. It's important to know when to trust your instincts (and when not to).
- With awareness and focused training, you can enhance your intuitive decision-making.



This summary is presented in 2 key sections:

- The powers and pitfalls of snap judgments; and
- How to improve intuitive decision-making



Part 1: The Power and Pitfalls of Snap Judgments



Thin-Slicing: How We Glean Insight from Limited Information



"Thin-slicing" refers to our innate ability to discern patterns and draw conclusions from minimal data. Such conclusions can be as accurate (or even more so) than those made from comprehensive analyses.



Gladwell shares several examples to illustrate how we can glean a lot from very little.

- Predicting relationship success: Psychologist Dr. John Gottman runs a "Love Lab" where he conducts extensive research on couples. Gottman can observe a couple for just 15 minutes and predict with 90% accuracy if they'd still be married 15 years later. The accuracy goes up to 95% after a 1-hour session.
 - Gottman's skill is like *decoding Morse Code*. To the untrained eye, the codes look like random dots and dashes. But experts can easily decipher the messages, and even identify a sender by the rhythm of the codes (just like voice recognition).
 - Having studied thousands of couples, Gottman can translate their interactions into "emotional dots and dashes." He can intuitively sieve through their words,

KEY QUOTES

"Our unconscious is a powerful force. But it's fallible."

"Just as we can teach ourselves to think logically and deliberately, we can also teach ourselves to make better snap judgments."

"Predicting divorce, like tracking Morse Code operators, is pattern recognition."

"Morse code is like speech. Everyone has a different voice...We have to listen to only a few characters to pick out an individual's pattern."

expressions, and reactions, to diagnose the state of the relationship. However, he doesn't try to read all the communication cues. He only zeroes in on 4 critical signs that predict relationship problems: criticism, contempt, defensiveness, and stonewalling.

- Understanding personalities through living spaces: Psychologist Samuel Gosling ran an experiment, where he had students evaluate their peers on 5 personality traits: extraversion, agreeableness, emotional stability, conscientiousness, and openness to experiences.
 - (i) One set of evaluation was done by close friends, while another was done by strangers who merely studied the subjects' dorm rooms. The results were compared against the subjects' self-evaluations.
 - (ii) The strangers more accurately predicted 3 of the 5 traits compared to the subjects' close friends. That's because our living spaces reflect our habits and preferences. The strangers could pick out these cues without being distracted by other irrelevant cues such as the subjects' looks or mannerisms.



Thin-slicing is a natural instinct. You assess new people and situations all the time, and you're generally good at it. The key is to eliminate irrelevant details and zoom in on the few things that really matter (elaborated below).



The Locked Door: Why We Can't Explain Our Intuition



The adaptive unconscious refers to the rapid-response system in our brain. It processes vast amounts of data without our conscious awareness, and makes split-second decisions based on past experiences and instincts.

- We're not fully aware of the reasons behind our snap judgments. It's like part of our mind is kept behind a locked door. It's always at work, yet we're not conscious of its workings. For example, tennis coach Vic Braden could predict when a player was about to serve a double fault, yet he couldn't explain how he knew.



Even when we think we understand our choices, our explanations may not reflect reality.

KEY QUOTES

"It is quite possible for people who have never met us and who have spent only twenty minutes thinking about us to come to a better understanding of who we are than people who have known us for years."

"Sometimes we're better off if the mind behind the locked door makes our decisions for us."

KEY QUOTES

"Our unconscious reactions come out of a locked room, and we can't look inside that room."

"We have, as human beings, a storytelling problem. We're a bit too quick to come up with explanations for things we don't really have an explanation for."

"We need to respect the fact that it is possible to know without knowing why we know and accept that—sometimes—we're better off that way."

- We might think we're doing one thing, when we're actually doing something else. For instance, baseball player Ted Williams could confidently explain how he played so well. Yet, slow-motion footage revealed that his actions didn't match his descriptions.
- During speed dating, participants meet a series of potential romantic partners in quick succession. They can decide within minutes if they'd like to see that person again, yet they find it hard to explain their choices. Often, they may choose partners who're different from their stated criteria, because they don't know the criteria being used by their unconscious mind.



We think that we're acting from our own free will, when our behaviors are often influenced by subtle cues around us.

- The power of priming: In an experiment, participants were asked to form sentences from words. One group was given words associated with politeness (e.g. "yield," "patient," "respect"), while the other was given words associated with rudeness (e.g. "intrude," "aggressive," "rudeness"). The participants primed with rudeness later interrupted a researcher while he was engaged in a discussion, while those primed with politeness waited patiently without interrupting.
- In another experiment, participants were challenged to tie 2 ropes dangling from the ceiling. The ropes were positioned far apart, so you can't reach both ropes at the same time. Many were stumped until the tester discreetly made one rope swing, hinting at the solution—to swing 1 rope while holding the other, then grab the swinging rope on its return swing and tie the 2 ropes. When the participants were asked to explain how they came up with the answer, almost all of them came up with some logical explanation. They didn't realize how their unconscious mind had picked up on the subtle hint to arrive at the answer.
- In short, we make unconscious, split-second decisions without knowing why. When our conscious mind tries to rationalize these decisions, we end up creating stories that might be untrue.



We live in world that demands hard facts and evidence, and we're often expected to explain how we arrive at our

conclusions or decisions. Such attempts to rationalize our choices can lead to misleading narratives. Gladwell believes that it's sometimes better to trust our instincts, and to accept that snap judgments can be valid even if we can't explain them.



The Warren Harding Error: The Pitfalls of First Impressions



Snap judgments are powerful, but our first impressions can be misleading due to unconscious biases and flawed assumptions. The "Warren Harding Error" is named after Warren G. Harding, the 29th U.S. president.

- Harding was elected largely because of his appearance. He *looked* like a leader—with his tall stature, commanding presence, and distinguished facial features—so much so that people overlooked his lack of skills and experience in governance and leadership. Unfortunately, appearances can be deceptive, and Harding turned out to be one of the worst presidents in American history.
- This error isn't limited to politics. A disproportionate number of Fortune 500 CEOs are tall, pointing to our tendency to associate height with leadership, even though there's no factual basis for it.



Our attitudes operate on 2 levels: conscious and unconscious. Our conscious attitudes are the stated values that we use intentionally to guide our behaviors. Our unconscious attitudes are the automatic associations and judgments that we form unknowingly.

- No matter what your stated beliefs are, your actions and decisions are influenced by your unconsciously beliefs/attitudes. For example, if you value equality but are unconsciously biased toward people of color, you may spontaneously lean away from them or avoid eye contact.
- You can uncover your hidden biases using the Implicit Association Test (IAT). This psychological tool measures the automatic connections that you make between 2 things.
 - (i) Participants are asked to link a series of positive or negative words with specific categories like race or gender. The faster you link 2 words, the stronger their

"We...have to acknowledge and understand those circumstances when rapid cognition leads us astray."

"We don't deliberately choose our unconscious attitudes... we may not even be aware of them."

"Being short is probably as much of a handicap to corporate success as being a woman or an African American."

association in your mind. For example, millions of Americans subconsciously link the words “evil” and “criminal” with “African American.”

- (ii) The unconscious attitudes revealed by the IAT are often different from our expressed beliefs, and it is our unconscious attitudes that drive our spontaneous/unplanned reactions.



Such biases have a real-world impact. In a study, testers of varying races and genders were tasked to visit car dealerships to negotiate car prices. They dressed similarly and were equipped with the same negotiation script. Yet, white men consistently received the best price offers, while females and minorities received less favorable terms.

- Although our biases operate beneath our consciousness, we're not entirely helpless against them. For example, car salesman Bob Golomb deliberately treats every customer the same way, regardless of their background or appearance. He gives everyone a fair and consistent price instead of second-guessing how much they would be willing to pay. This unbiased approach has earned him the loyalty of his customers and helped him to outperform his peers consistently.



Limitations of Market Research in Consumer Preferences



Consumer decisions are complex and multi-faceted, and people often can't explain their unconscious choices. Thus, market research is often unreliable in predicting consumer preferences.

- In the early 1980s, Coca-Cola was losing market share steadily to Pepsi. Pepsi's ads showed people choosing Pepsi over Coke in a blind taste-test. So, Coke launched "New Coke" with a sweeter taste similar to Pepsi's. Blind tests confirmed that people preferred the taste of New Coke over the original. Yet, New Coke failed to take off, and Coca-Cola was forced to bring back the Classic Coke. Meanwhile, Pepsi never overtook Coke as the market leader. What can we learn from this example?

- (i) The blind tests involved just a sip of the drink, which didn't reflect actual consumption patterns. People may

KEY QUOTES

"Our first impressions are generated by our experiences and our environment, which means that we can...alter the way we thin-slice...by changing the experiences that comprise those impressions."

prefer Pepsi's sweeter taste in 1 sip, but find it overpowering when they finish a whole bottle.

- (ii) Consumer preferences for Coke went beyond taste—purchase decisions are also influenced by brand loyalty, cultural perceptions, product packaging, etc. Feedback on 1 aspect of the product may not predict purchase decisions.
- Specifically, Louis Cheskin found that consumer preferences are influenced by many factors besides product quality. These include: packaging, brand expectations, and context. For example:
 - (i) Margarine became more popular after he changed its color from white to yellow and wrapped it in foil, so it resembled butter.
 - (ii) When brandies were decanted into plain bottles, people could no longer differentiate between premium and normal brands.

 Our first impressions may not reflect our long-term preferences. This is especially true for ground-breaking products that we're unfamiliar with: we may claim to hate the product when we're simply unused to it.

- Take the Aeron Chair for example. It was introduced in the '90s by Herman Miller, with a radically different design from office chairs of that era. The chair was meant to be aesthetically pleasing and ergonomically superior, yet feedback from market research was discouraging. Many people found it strange or ugly, and most didn't see it as a luxury chair.
- Miller launched the Aeron Chair regardless. Initially, reception was lukewarm, but its popularity grew as people began to appreciate its ergonomic benefits and aesthetic appeal. The Aeron Chair eventually became a symbol of status and modern innovation, and was even displayed at the Museum of Modern Art.

 Simple preferences can also become distorted by over-analysis.

- Often, consumers cannot explain their subconscious choices. When they're asked to explain their preferences or assess

KEY QUOTES

"The mistake Coca-Cola made was in attributing their loss in share to Pepsi entirely to the product. But what counts for an awful lot in colas is the brand imagery, and they lost sight of that."
—William Rhea

"It is the new and different that is always most vulnerable to market research."

specific qualities (e.g. texture, rhythm, aesthetics), they may over-think and invent narratives that don't reflect their true preferences.

- For example, when people were asked to taste and rank different jams, their rankings were closely aligned with experts' opinions. But, when they were asked to explain why they liked/disliked the jams, their rankings became different from the experts'.



Part 2: Improving Intuitive Decision-Making



Structured Spontaneity: Balancing Intuition and Analysis



Snap judgments and spontaneous actions may seem random, but they're actually built on past experiences, learning and practice.



To make effective snap decisions, you need the right blend of intuition and analysis.

- Specifically, apply deliberate thinking (which is slow and thorough) and intuitive thinking (which is fast and adaptable) in the right contexts and combination:
 - (i) Use deliberate thinking when there's a clearly-defined task, ample time, and suitable tools for analysis. Then, use the results of the detailed analysis to create a *structure for intuitive thinking*.
 - (ii) Don't try to use logical thinking/analysis to explain something visual or intuitive (e.g. dance moves or solutions to complex/creative problems). When we describe something in words (a left-brain activity), it can interfere with our visual/intuitive ability (a right-brain function). That's why you can easily recall your friend's face, yet you struggle to describe it in words.
- In 2002, the U.S. Department of Defense organized a war game called the Millennium Challenge to simulate a confrontation between the U.S. and a smaller rogue state.

KEY QUOTES

"Spontaneity isn't random.... How good people's decisions are under the fast-moving, high-stress conditions of rapid cognition is a function of training and rules and rehearsal."

KEY QUOTES

- (i) The U.S. forces were represented by the Blue Team, which was equipped with sophisticated computer systems and databases to analyze enemy data and possible strategies. The rogue state was represented by the Red Team, which was led by a retired Marine (Paul Van Riper) who relied mainly on experience and gut instincts to lead his team.
- (ii) Despite the Blue Team's advance technology, they were outmaneuvered by the Red Team. Van Riper and his team did their analyses *before* the battle, then relied on their instincts and combat experience to respond nimbly during the battle. By contrast, the Blue Team was constantly analyzing and debating their strategies; getting so lost in the details that couldn't tap on their intuition.
- A similar pattern can be found in improvisational (improv) comedy. Performers step onto the stage without a pre-defined role or a script. They come up with material on the spot (or even take suggestions from the audience) to improvise as they go.
 - (i) Improv seems entirely spontaneous, but it operates on established rules that enable performers to react swiftly on stage. One foundational principle is the "Yes, And..." rule: when a performer introduces an idea, others must accept and build on it, so the scene can progress smoothly and organically.
 - (ii) The actors rehearse the rules so frequently that they become deeply-ingrained and can be applied intuitively during a performance.



Too much information can hinder decision-making. Be frugal with your use of information: identify and focus only on the essential factors, so you don't get bogged down by irrelevant data.

- Remember: thin-slicing is not about making decisions with insufficient data. It is about making decisions with the right data, however minimal.
- For example, the Cook County Hospital was overwhelmed by the sheer number of potential heart attack patients arriving at their Emergency Department. They couldn't admit every patient for further tests, yet they couldn't risk sending patients home if they were truly suffering from a heart attack.

"They were so focused on the mechanics and the process that they never looked at the problem holistically. In the act of tearing something apart, you lose its meaning."
—Paul Van Riper

"When we talk about analytic versus intuitive decision making, neither is good or bad. What is bad is if you use either of them in an inappropriate circumstance."
—Paul Van Riper

"Snap judgments can be made in a snap because they are frugal, and if we want to protect our snap judgments, we have to take steps to protect that frugality."

"You need to know very little to find the underlying signature of a complex phenomenon."

Based on extensive research, Dr. Brendan Reilly developed a simple decision tree for identifying heart attack patients, using only 4 critical factors: ECG readings, pain from unstable angina, fluid in the patient's lungs, and systolic blood pressure. This proved to be 70% more effective than the original methods. In short, less can be more.



Making Decisions Under Stress or Trauma



Stress can cloud our intuition. When we jump to hasty conclusions in tense or high-stress situations, it can lead to disastrous results.

- In 1999, Amadou Diallo—a West African immigrant—was tragically killed by police officers in New York. Diallo was taking a walk outside his apartment building when he encountered 4 police officers. The officers started shooting when they thought Diallo was drawing a gun, when he was just reaching for his wallet. In another incident, college football player Robert Russ was shot by a Chicago police officer during a traffic stop. How did these happen?
- Under normal circumstances, most of us can “read” others’ intentions and emotions through their expressions and micro-expressions. Psychologists Silvan Tomkins and Paul Ekman developed the Facial Action Coding System (FACS) which documents a myriad of human emotions expressed through a combination of facial-muscle movements, including subtle, fleeting micro-expressions.
- However, people with disorders (e.g. autism) may suffer from mind-blindness, i.e. they find it hard to discern others’ emotional states. When normal people encounter high-stress or life-or-death situations, they may also develop temporary mind-blindness (or what Gladwell calls “temporary autism”). Time seems to stand still, and we may experience tunnel vision or temporary deafness as the body zeroes in on the threat and blocks out all other signals. For a time, we lose our ability to read others’ intentions or emotions.
- We also need “white space”, or a moment to effectively read or respond to others. In intense scenarios, we might rush to conclusion, worsening the effects of temporarily mind-blindness.

KEY QUOTES

“There is enough accessible information on a face to make everyday mind reading possible.”

“I think that we become temporarily autistic...in situations when we run out of time.”



Fortunately, we can train ourselves to respond more effectively in times of extreme stress.

- Our heart-rate increases with our stress levels. According to Lt. Col. Dave Grossman, we perform optimally in stressful situations when our heart rate is between 115-145 beats per minute. Beyond 145, our cognitive abilities start to decline. Past 175, our mental capabilities are comparable to animals'.
- The military and police forces often use simulations to train people to handle high-pressure situations. For instance, trainees may panic when they're first shot by a plastic capsule. But after repeat hits, they're usually able to continue operating in a relatively calm manner.



We can also control our environmental cues to influence our unconscious attitudes/beliefs. For example:

- Some police departments are shifting toward one-officer patrols. That's because solo officers are more likely to slow down to assess the situation cautiously, and seek backup rather than rush into a situation.
- The world of orchestra used to be dominated by men, since it was widely believed that women lacked the physical abilities to play as well as men. This changed with the introduction of blind auditions: when musicians play behind a screen, judges must assess them purely by the quality of music. This removes visual biases associated with age, race, gender, or appearance.
- People who displayed unconscious racial biases in IAT tests saw an improvement when they took the tests after engaging with positive representations of minority groups (e.g. watching the Olympics or reading about minority leaders). By interacting regularly with diverse types of people, you can recalibrate your unconscious beliefs.

KEY QUOTES

"With experience we become expert at using our behavior and our training to interpret—and decode—what lies behind our snap judgments and first impressions."

"If we can control the environment in which rapid cognition takes place, then we can control rapid cognition."



Other Details in the Book to Look Out For

This book is packed with detailed stories, examples, and research to help us understand the power of and pitfalls of our intuition, and how

we can improve our rapid cognition to make better decisions in all areas of life. You can visit www.gladwellbooks.com for more details, visit www.implicit.harvard.edu for take various IATs for free.



About the Author



Malcolm Gladwell is an author, journalist, and public speaker. He has written for The Washington Post and The New Yorker and previously received the National Magazine Award for profiles. Gladwell has written several books, including New York Times bestsellers *The Tipping Point* and *Outliers*. In 2005, Gladwell was named among TIME magazine's 100 most influential people.

KEY QUOTES